

St Dunstan & St Paul's - Kids

UK Family Tour

St Dunstan in the East: The Church the Trees Took Back

You're about to walk into one of London's best secrets — a ruined church with trees growing right through its windows. St Dunstan-in-the-East was built around nine hundred years ago. It survived the Great Fire of London in 1666 — mostly — and the famous architect Christopher Wren patched it up and gave it a clever steeple. Then, in 1941, during World War Two, German bombs gutted it in the Blitz. Only the walls and Wren's tower survived. Here's a story about that steeple: Wren designed it standing on four curved legs, and people said it would fall down. Years later, when a big storm damaged church steeples all over London, someone rushed to tell Wren's people that St Dunstan's must surely have collapsed. The answer came back, cool as you like: not that steeple. It stood through the storm — and through the Blitz too. After the war, London decided not to rebuild the church. Instead, in 1971, they planted a garden inside it. Now vines pour through the empty stone windows and a fountain bubbles where people once prayed. It's a place where nature won — gently. Speak quietly here; office workers come to eat lunch in the quietest spot in the city.

The Saint Who Grabbed the Devil's Nose

Have you ever wondered who St Dunstan actually was? This garden is named after him, and he's one of the best characters in all of English history. Dunstan lived more than a thousand years ago, born around the year nine hundred and nine. He was a monk, but he was also a craftsman: he could work metal, hammering gold and silver and iron into beautiful things, and he loved to play the harp. People even whispered that his harp once played a tune all by itself, hanging on the wall, which made them a little bit afraid of him.

Here's the story everyone remembers. One day Dunstan was busy in his workshop, bent over his little furnace, when a stranger appeared and started pestering him. The stranger kept changing shape: first an old man, then a cheeky boy, then someone trying to trick him into all sorts of mischief. Dunstan realised this was no ordinary visitor. This was the Devil himself, come to tempt him. So Dunstan did something wonderfully bold. He quietly slid his iron tongs into the hot coals and waited, and waited, until they were glowing red. Then he spun round and grabbed the Devil right by the nose. The story goes that the Devil howled so loudly he was heard for miles, and he never came back to bother Dunstan again.

Because Dunstan worked with hammers and metal, he became the special saint, the patron saint, of blacksmiths and goldsmiths and silversmiths, and of musicians too. Blacksmiths were so proud of him that for hundreds of years they hung a picture of Dunstan and his red-hot tongs above their forges.

Dunstan didn't stay in his workshop, though. He became one of the most powerful men in England, an adviser to kings, and finally the Archbishop of Canterbury, which is the top churchman in the whole country. He helped crown kings, and he even wrote a coronation ceremony so good that pieces of it are still used when a king or queen is crowned today.

One more thing to clear up. There are actually two St Dunstan churches in London. This one is called St

Dunstan in the East, and there's another one over to the west called, you guessed it, St Dunstan in the West. So the "East" in the name isn't about the saint at all. It just tells Londoners which of the two churches you mean. Now, next time you see a blacksmith in a film hammering glowing metal, you'll know whose picture used to hang over the fire.

A Church with Nine Lives

Look at the stone walls around you, and here's a puzzle: not all of them are the same age. This one small church has been knocked down and built back up so many times that it's a bit like a cat with nine lives.

The very first church here went up around nine hundred years ago, when London was a smaller, muddier place and this spot was close to the busy riverside where ships unloaded wine and fish. Over the centuries people added bits and mended bits, the way you'd patch a favourite pair of shoes.

Then came the Great Fire of 1666, which you've heard about. It scorched this church badly. But instead of knocking it flat and starting again, the people of the parish decided to repair it, and they hired the most famous architect in England, Christopher Wren, to build a brand new tower and a soaring stone steeple. That tower is the tall part you can still see today, and it's the oldest thing standing here now.

Life number three is the strangest. By about the year eighteen hundred, the old patched-up body of the church had grown weak and crumbly, and everyone worried it might simply fall down. So they knocked most of it down on purpose, keeping only Wren's tower, and built a fresh new church around it. The architect this time was a man named David Laing, and he made it in a pointy, spiky style with tall arched windows, the shape you can still trace in these ruined walls. That new church opened in the year eighteen twenty-one.

So think about what you're really looking at. The tower is Wren's, more than three hundred years old. The walls with the elegant pointed windows are Laing's, about two hundred years old. And the garden bursting through all of it is the newest life of all, younger even than your grandparents.

Here's the wild part. Every time people rebuilt this church, they thought they were making it last forever. None of them could have guessed that one day it wouldn't be a church at all, but a garden where you're standing right now, with birds nesting in Wren's tower and flowers spilling out of David Laing's windows. A building can have many lives, and this one isn't finished yet.

The Night It Fell and the Garden That Grew

Now for the night that changed everything. Close your eyes and imagine London in the spring of nineteen forty-one, in the middle of the Second World War. For months, enemy planes had been flying over the city at night, dropping bombs in the dark. Londoners called this the Blitz.

On the night of the tenth of May, nineteen forty-one, came the worst raid of them all. Hundreds of aircraft roared over the city and the sky glowed orange with fire. That was the night the bombs found this church. They smashed through the roof and blew out every window, and when morning came the whole middle of the church was gone. Only the outer walls were left standing, and, once again, Wren's tough old tower, which simply refused to fall.

Here's the amazing part: that terrible night of the tenth of May turned out to be the very last big raid of the Blitz. After it, the night bombers largely went away. So this little church took one of the final, heaviest blows of the whole ordeal.

When the war ended, London had hundreds of ruined churches and had to choose which ones to rebuild. The people in charge looked at St Dunstan and made an unusual decision. They decided not to rebuild it

at all. Instead, in nineteen seventy-one, they did something gentle and clever: they turned the broken ruin into a garden and opened it to everyone, for free.

And look what happened next. They planted climbing plants that came pouring out of the empty windows, and trees that reach up where the roof used to be, so that today branches make a green ceiling over your head. A little fountain trickles in the middle. Because the high walls block the wind, it stays calm and sheltered in here even when the streets outside are blustery, which is exactly why so many plants and birds love it.

So this place has been three things: a church for hundreds of years, a bombed-out ruin for thirty, and now a secret garden. The bombs tried to erase it, but instead of vanishing, it turned into one of the most peaceful spots in the whole roaring city. Stand still for a moment and listen. That quiet is the sound of a place that came back to life.

St Paul's: The Dome That Refused to Burn

That giant dome ahead of you was, for two hundred and fifty years, the tallest thing in London. St Paul's Cathedral was built by Sir Christopher Wren after the Great Fire of 1666 burned down the old cathedral — along with more than thirteen thousand houses. Wren spent thirty-five years building it, from 1675 to 1710, and he lived to see it finished, which almost never happens with cathedrals — most took centuries. His son placed the final stone. The dome is one of the biggest in the world, and inside is the Whispering Gallery: whisper against the wall on one side, and someone on the far side, thirty meters away, can hear you. The sound sneaks around the curved wall like a secret. St Paul's most famous moment came in World War Two. As bombs rained down and the streets around it burned, Prime Minister Churchill ordered that the cathedral must be saved “at all costs.” Volunteer firewatchers lived on the roof, kicking burning bombs off the dome. One bomb actually pierced the dome and fell inside — and didn't explode. The photo of the dome standing untouched above a sea of smoke and flame became the most famous image of London's survival. Remember the keyhole view from Richmond Park? This is that same dome, up close.

Climbing to the Golden Gallery

Let's climb this dome together, at least in our imaginations, because it's a proper adventure with hundreds of steps and a secret hidden in the walls.

You start on the cathedral floor and head up a winding stone staircase, round and round, two hundred and fifty-seven steps, until you reach a narrow balcony that runs all the way around the inside of the dome, high above the ground. This is the famous Whispering Gallery. Here's the trick to try. If a friend stands on the far side, right across the curve, and whispers against the wall, you can press your ear to the wall on your side and hear them almost as clearly as if they were next to you. Your whisper doesn't shoot across the empty middle. Instead it creeps around the curved wall, hugging the stone all the way round to the other side. For a long time nobody understood why, until a clever scientist called Lord Rayleigh worked out the secret back in eighteen seventy-eight. Sound, it turns out, can run around a smooth curved wall like a marble rolling round the inside of a bowl.

While you're up there, tip your head back and look at the very top of the dome. Those enormous paintings, showing scenes from the life of Saint Paul, were made by an artist named James Thornhill about three hundred years ago. Look closely and you'll notice they're painted almost all in browns and greys, with no bright colours, so that from far below they look like carved stone statues instead of paintings. It's a clever trick of the eyes.

But we're not finished climbing. Keep going up and you reach the Stone Gallery, outside now, in the fresh air, three hundred and seventy-eight steps from the ground. And if your legs are brave enough, you climb higher still, up tighter and twistier stairs inside the dome, all the way to the little Golden Gallery right at the top: five hundred and twenty-eight steps in total. From up there you can see the whole of London spread out beneath you, the river, the bridges, the towers, everything.

Five hundred and twenty-eight steps is a lot. That's like climbing the stairs of a tall block of flats, and then doing it twice more. So if you ever come back and climb it for real, count them as you go, and remember that the whisper you heard down at step two hundred and fifty-seven travelled around that wall using a secret it kept from everybody for two hundred years.

The Bomb Beneath the Cathedral

Here's a true story that almost nobody knows, and it's as tense as any film. It happened in September nineteen forty, right at the start of the wartime bombing, and it very nearly destroyed this whole cathedral in a single blow.

One night an enemy plane dropped a huge bomb that came screaming down right beside St Paul's, near the front steps at the western end. But it didn't go off. Instead it punched deep into the ground and buried itself, and when the soldiers came to look, they realised the worst: it was a delayed-action bomb, the kind with a timer ticking away inside, built to explode later, when nobody expected it. And it was so close to the cathedral that if it went off, it could bring the whole west front crashing down.

The bomb was stuck twenty-seven feet underground, deeper than a house is tall. A team of army engineers, led by an officer named Robert Davies, had to dig it out by hand, knowing all the while that it might explode at any second. It took them three whole days. To make things worse, the bomb had cracked a gas pipe, and twice the diggers had to scramble out when the tunnel caught fire.

At last they reached it and hauled the enormous bomb up to the surface. Now what? They couldn't set it off here, so close to St Paul's. So Davies did something incredibly brave. He loaded the live bomb onto a lorry and drove it himself, slowly, through the empty streets of London, all the way out to a wild open space called Hackney Marshes. There they let it explode safely. And what a bang it made: it blew a crater in the ground about a hundred feet across. Just imagine that hole opening up under the cathedral instead.

For saving St Paul's, Robert Davies was given the George Cross, which is one of the very highest awards for bravery there is, and he was only about the second or third person ever to receive it.

So next time you look up at that calm, magnificent dome, remember that it's still standing partly because a group of soldiers spent three days digging a ticking bomb out of the earth, and one brave man drove it away through the dark. The cathedral survived the war, but it took a lot of very cool heads to keep it that way.

The Cathedral of Famous Days, and a Magic Staircase

Some buildings just watch the world go by. This one has been at the very centre of the biggest days in the whole country, the days people never forget.

When Britain wants to say goodbye to a hero, or celebrate something enormous, it often comes here. In nineteen sixty-five, when the great wartime leader Winston Churchill died, his funeral was held right here, and it was so important that leaders from more than a hundred countries came to London for it. As his coffin passed along the river afterwards, the tall cranes at the docks slowly bowed down, one by one, to say farewell.

And in nineteen eighty-one came one of the most watched days in history. Prince Charles married Lady Diana Spencer in this cathedral, and something like seven hundred and fifty million people around the world watched it on television. Diana's dress had a train, the long trailing bit of fabric behind her, that was nearly eight metres long, so long it had to be carefully squashed into the carriage with her. The couple chose St Paul's instead of the usual royal church because it was bigger, let more guests come, and gave a longer, grander ride through the streets. Kings and queens have celebrated their jubilees here too, the big anniversaries of their reigns.

Now here's something just for you. Hidden inside one of the towers of this cathedral is a curling stone staircase that seems to float, spiralling up with nothing underneath holding it except the clever way each step leans on the one below. And if it looks strangely familiar, that's because a film crew once used it as a secret set. This is the staircase that Harry Potter climbs to reach Professor Trelawney's Divination

classroom in the Prisoner of Azkaban. So the very same swirling steps that have hosted kings and queens also became a corner of Hogwarts.

That's the magic of this place. One day it's the whole nation crowded inside for a funeral or a wedding, and another day it's a wizard climbing to a lesson in the movies. When you stand under that dome, you're standing in the spot where Britain comes to remember, to celebrate, to cry and to cheer. Not bad for a building that a burning city and a ticking bomb both tried, and failed, to destroy.